Unit 1 of 10, November, Sociology and Economics

Reading the exam way

Part One of the official paper is worth 12 marks out of 20. This unit trains the habits behind every one of those marks: reading in passes, decoding what a question really wants, and answering in your own words.

Session 1: Lesson

1 Meet the paper

The English paper for LS and SE lasts **2 hours 30 minutes**. It has two parts: **Reading Comprehension (12 marks)** on one selection of about 700 words, and **Writing (8 marks)**, where you choose one of two prompts and write 250–300 words.

Part One always follows the same pattern of sections.

Section	What it tests	Marks (LS, June 2019)
A	Written answers in 1–4 sentences: identify, scan, explain, infer	4
B	False statements to rewrite correctly	1
C	Organisation, tone, credibility, audience	4
D	Conclusion from a table or graph	1.5
E	Vocabulary in context (spelling must be correct)	1
F	Reference words	0.5
Part Two	One essay, 250–300 words: content 3.5, language 3.5, tidiness 1	8

From the grading schemes: answers are marked point by point, usually 0.5 mark per idea. Two clear ideas in two sentences earn a full mark; one long paragraph with one idea does not.

2 Read in three passes

Expert readers do not read an exam text once from top to bottom. They read it in passes, each with a different goal:

1. **Skim** the text: the title, the preview line, and the **first and last sentence of each paragraph**. Goal: the general idea in two minutes.
2. **Read the questions** before reading in detail. Now you know what to look for.
3. **Scan**: move quickly to the paragraph a question names and hunt for the key words. Only then **construct your answer**.

Task 1.

Self-check. After skimming only, what is the selection mainly about?

a. A bridge that collapsed in Tripoli.

b. How social media spreads false news, what it costs, and how readers can resist it.
c. How websites earn money from advertising.

3 Questions speak in synonyms

Examiners rarely copy the text's words into the question. They use a **synonym** or a **paraphrase**, so you must scan for the idea, not only the word. Match each word from a question with the words that express the same idea in the text.

Task 2. Question word ↔ text word: match each question word (1–4) with the text words (A–D).

1. financial motive
2. loss of trust
3. divided society
4. checking a photo

A. "a reverse image search" (P7)
B. "communities split into separate groups" (P5)
C. "Every click brings advertising income" (P4)
D. "people begin to doubt all news" (P5)

4 Command words decoded

Command word	What the examiner wants
Identify	Show who or what something is: name the main idea, a reason, a person. Short and exact.
Define, list, locate	Define: say what a term means and how it differs from similar things. List: write related points that start with the same part of speech. Locate: find where it is in the text.
Describe, explain, discuss, clarify	Describe: give a picture in words. Explain: make clear and give reasons, especially *cause and effect* or steps in order.
Infer	Draw a meaning the writer suggests but does not state. The writer *implies*; you, the reader, *infer* and say it explicitly.
Analyse, evaluate	Analyse: examine details and the links between them to reach a conclusion. Evaluate: judge the value of something, its pluses and minuses, with evidence.

Sort these real-style question stems by what they ask you to do.

Task 3. Command word sorter

Categories: Identify / List / locate / Explain / clarify / Infer / Evaluate

1. Identify two reasons behind the mother's sadness. _____
2. What can you infer about the writer's view of schools? _____
3. Explain how the new rule changed the family's evenings. _____

4. List three symptoms mentioned in paragraph 4. _____
5. Is the writer's solution realistic? Justify your answer. _____
6. Who is responsible for the decision in paragraph 2? _____
7. Based on paragraph 8, what does his smile suggest? _____
8. Why did the experiment fail? Clarify. _____

5 Three depths of reading

CRDP describes three levels of comprehension. The paper mixes all three, and the deeper ones carry the harder marks.

Level	What you do	Typical question
Literal (on the lines)	Find information that is stated: facts, sequences, stated causes, characters, setting.	"Scan paragraph 3 for two indicators…"
Inferential (between the lines)	Build meaning that is suggested: implied causes, the writer's attitude, the meaning of a word from context, what a pronoun refers to.	"Infer one measure that could…"
Critical (beyond the lines)	Judge the text: evidence, facts versus opinions, whether an argument holds, how it connects to the wider world.	"Do you agree with the writer? Justify."

Task 4. Which depth does each question need?

Categories: Literal / Inferential / Critical

1. How many students took part in the survey? _____
2. What does "a master that decides when we sleep" suggest about phones? _____
3. Is a single survey enough to prove the writer's point? Explain. _____
4. According to paragraph 7, what do experts recommend? _____
5. How does the writer feel about the families who use a phone basket? _____
6. Would this solution work in your own home? Justify. _____

6 Answer in your own words

Section A of the official paper says: *Answer each of the following questions in 1–4 complete sentences using your own words.* Four habits earn the marks:

1. **Echo the question** in your first words, so the answer stands alone: "The first reason was…".
2. **Count the marks.** A 1-mark question usually wants two ideas (0.5 each). Number them in your head: *first… second…*
3. **Rephrase**: change the words and the structure, keep the meaning. Copying whole lines loses marks for language.
4. **Stop** when the ideas are given. Four sentences is a maximum, not a target.

> **Allowed to keep:** names, numbers and technical terms (melatonin, algorithm, insulin). You cannot paraphrase "Tripoli", and you do not need to.

7 Inferring: reading between the lines

An inference is never a guess. It is built from a **clue in the text** plus **common knowledge**, and you should be able to point to the clue. In your answer, show the link: “Since…, we can infer that…”.

Task 5.

Clue (P1): “Shocked, she shared it at once with a warning to her friends.” **What can you infer about Rana?**

a. She wanted to spread false news on purpose.
b. She works for a news website.
c. She acted on emotion without checking the source.

Task 6.

Clue (P8): “Today she runs a small fact-checking page.” **What does this suggest?**

a. Rana turned her mistake into a lesson and now helps others avoid it.
b. Rana stopped using social media.
c. Rana was hired by a newspaper.

Session 1: Revision cards

The three passes 1. **Skim** : title, preview, first and last sentence of each paragraph. 2. **Read the questions.** 3. **Scan** the named paragraph for the key idea, then answer.	**Skim vs scan** **Skim** = read fast for the *general idea*. **Scan** = search fast for *specific information* (a name, a number, a reason).
Identify Show **who or what** something is: name the idea, reason or person exactly. Short, precise answers.	**Explain** Make clear and **give reasons** : show cause and effect, or the steps in order. Use *because, so, as a result*.
Imply or infer? The **writer implies** (suggests). The **reader infers** (works it out and states it). Infer = clue + knowledge.	**Evaluate** Judge the **value** of something: give its pluses and minuses, each **backed by evidence** .

The three depths **Literal** : on the lines (stated). **Inferential** : between the lines (suggested). **Critical** : beyond the lines (judged).	**1 mark = ?** Usually **two ideas, 0.5 each** , in 1–4 complete sentences, in your own words. Echo the question at the start.

Session 1: Practice

In the following selection, the writer examines how social media has changed the way young people receive the news, and what it costs society. Read it carefully, and then answer the questions that follow.

The Price of a Click

Original practice text written for this platform. Names, places and figures are invented for practice.

1 On a rainy evening in Tripoli, Rana, a nineteen-year-old business student, saw a dramatic photo of a collapsed bridge on her phone. Shocked, **she** shared it at once with a warning to her friends. Within an hour, the post had been shared more than 4,000 times. There was only one problem: the bridge was standing, and the photo had been taken in another country six years earlier.

2 Rana's mistake is far from rare. In a recent survey of 900 young adults in Lebanon, three out of four said that social media is their main source of news. Fewer than one in five said they check where a story comes from before passing it on, so false stories circulate almost as freely as true ones.

3 Part of the problem lies in how social platforms choose what we see. Their programs, called algorithms, are designed to show each user the content **which** is most likely to keep him or her scrolling. Since anger and fear hold our attention longer than calm facts, the most alarming posts are pushed to the top, whether they are true or not.

4 Money also plays a role. Every click brings advertising income, so some websites compete with sensational headlines that promise more than the article delivers. "A headline used to summarise a story; now it often sells it," says Ziad Khoury, a journalism lecturer. "When attention becomes the product, accuracy becomes optional."

5 The consequences reach far beyond one embarrassing post. When false reports spread, people begin to doubt all news, including the reliable kind, and the credibility of serious journalists suffers. Moreover, since each user mostly sees opinions similar to his or her own, communities split into separate groups that no longer listen to one another.

6 Ironically, this generation has more information at its fingertips than any before it, yet it may be less informed. Endless headlines create the feeling of knowing what is happening, while the full story stays unread.

7 The solution is not to switch off the media but to read it more wisely. Before sharing, readers can ask three quick questions: who published this, when, and do other trusted sources report it too? A reverse image search takes less than a minute and can verify whether a photo is new. Universities and schools can also teach media literacy as seriously as they teach mathematics.

8 As for Rana, she learned her lesson. Today she runs a small fact-checking page with three classmates on their campus, **where** students send in doubtful posts to be checked before they spread.

9 The media can be a window on the world or a mirror that only shows us what we want to see. Which one **it** becomes depends, in the end, on the reader's finger: the one that pauses before it clicks.

Exercise 1: Section A, exam style

4 marks, about 20 min

Answer each question in 1–4 complete sentences using your own words.

1. Based on paragraph 1, identify two mistakes Rana made. (01)

2. Scan paragraphs 3 and 4 for two reasons false stories spread quickly online. (01)

3. Based on paragraphs 5 and 6, explain how false news harms society. (01)

4. Based on paragraphs 7 and 8, infer one measure an individual and one measure an educational institution could take against false news. (01)

Exercise 2: Decode before you answer

no marks, 10 min

For each question, write (a) the command word, (b) the depth of reading it needs, and (c) how many ideas the answer needs.

1. Based on paragraph 2, identify two findings of the survey. (01)
2. What can you infer about the writer's attitude towards technology in the last paragraph? (01)
3. Do you think the writer's solution is practical for Lebanese families? Justify your answer. (01)
4. Explain how the writer uses the opening story to introduce the topic. (01)

Exercise 3: Own words

no marks, 15 min

Rephrase each sentence from your text. Keep the meaning, change the words and the structure. Test yourself with the own-words meter in Lesson 1, step 6.

1. “Rana’s mistake is far from rare.” (P2)

2. “Money also plays a role.” (P4)

3. “The solution is not to switch off the media but to read it more wisely.” (P7)

Session 2: Lesson

1 False statements: the six traps

Section B gives sentences that are *false because they misinterpret the meaning stated or conveyed in the selection*. Each is a true idea with one thing changed. Find the change and you have the answer. The usual traps are:

Trap	Example of the change
Antonym: a word is replaced by its opposite	later → *earlier*
Tense: the time is changed	is falling asleep earlier → *used to fall asleep earlier*
General ↔ specific: “some” becomes “all”, or the reverse	some families → *all families*; only → *also*
Cause ↔ effect: the two are swapped	A causes B → *B causes A*
Wrong person: an act or opinion is given to someone else	the researcher said → *the mother said*
Wrong order: the sequence of events is changed	before → *after*

Task 1. Name the trap in each false statement (antonym, tense, general/specific, cause/effect, wrong person, wrong order), then correct it.

1. All young adults in the survey get their news mainly from social media. Trap: _____
2. Divided communities cause false news to appear. Trap: _____
3. Rana says that attention has become the product. Trap: _____
4. Algorithms push calm facts to the top of the feed. Trap: _____
5. Rana checked the photo before sharing it. Trap: _____

2 Rewriting a false statement

The official answer keeps the statement and corrects the changed part. Do not write “This is false because…”, and do not add a new idea. One clean, correct sentence earns the 0.5 mark.

> **Statement:** Diabetes 1 can be cured by regular doses of insulin.
> **Official correction (2019):** Diabetes 1 can be *treated* by regular doses of insulin.
> Only one word changed, because only one word was wrong.

Task 2.

Self-check. False: *All Lebanese families have introduced a phone basket.* Which correction is best?

a. This is false because the writer does not say all families.
b. Some families have introduced a phone basket in the living room.
c. Families should use phones less at night.

3 Reference words

Section F asks what a bold-typed word refers to. A pronoun needs an **antecedent**: the noun or idea it stands for, usually in the same or the previous sentence. Write the antecedent in full, as the text says it.

Kind	Words	Watch out
Personal	he, she, it, they, him, her, them, his, its, their…	*it* can refer to a whole idea, not only a noun.
Relative	who, whom, whose, which, that, **where**, **when**	The antecedent is usually just before it: *the room where…*
Demonstrative	this, that, these, those	*this* often sums up the previous sentence.
Indefinite	one, each, some, both, many, several, none…	Check singular or plural.

Exam tip: test your answer by putting it in place of the pronoun. “Charging the phone outside the bedroom, *outside the bedroom* it cannot call for attention” is clumsy but makes sense, so the reference is right.

4 Meaning from context

You will meet words you do not know. The sentence usually tells you what they mean, through one of these clues:

Clue	Signal	Example
Definition	is, means, called, a comma or dash	melatonin, *the hormone that makes us sleepy*
Synonym	or, also, a repeated idea	anxious, *nervous*
Antonym / contrast	but, unlike, however, while	*calm* facts, unlike alarming posts

Example	such as, like, including	symptoms such as *thirst, hunger*
General sense	the whole situation	a *sleepless* student with heads on desks

Task 3.

“Most passengers stayed calm, but a few became **frantic**, shouting and pushing towards the door.” **Which clue helps most?**

a. Definition
b. Example
c. Antonym / contrast

Task 4.

“The village depends on **aquifers**, underground layers of rock that hold water.” **Which clue helps most?**

a. Definition
b. Antonym / contrast
c. Example

5 The fill-in task

Section E gives a box of words underlined in the text and sentences with blanks. A fast method:

1. **Grammar:** what does the blank need? After *the* → a noun; after *very* → an adjective; after *to* → a verb.
2. **Meaning:** reread the word in its paragraph, then test it in the sentence.
3. **Spelling:** the official grading scheme says the spelling must be correct. Copy the word letter by letter.

Task 5.

Fill in the blanks: circulate (P2), sensational (P4), credibility (P5), verify (P7)

1. Rumours _____ quickly in small towns.
2. The witness lost all _____ when his story changed three times.
3. Always _____ a quotation before you use it in an essay.
4. The magazine printed a _____ cover story to boost its sales.

6 Putting Part One together

On exam day, a reliable route through Part One looks like this. Adapt the minutes to the plan you chose in Lesson 1.

1. **Skim** the text and the preview (5 min).
2. **Read all the questions** and underline the command words and paragraph numbers (5 min).
3. Do the **quick-win sections** first: false statements, reference words and vocabulary (15 min).

4. Then the **written answers** of Sections A and C, scanning paragraph by paragraph (35 min).
5. The **table or graph** question last if it is long (10 min), then check spelling.

Then try the timed mini-paper in Practice 2, Exercise 3.

Session 2: Revision cards

Antonym trap A word was replaced by its **opposite** (later → earlier, increase → decrease). Fix: put the original word back.	**General ↔ specific** *all, always, every, only, never* replacing *some, often, a few, also*. Watch for absolute words.
Cause ↔ effect The result is presented as the cause. “Bad grades cause late nights” instead of “late nights cause bad grades”.	**The six traps** Antonym · tense · general/specific · cause/effect · wrong person · wrong order.
Antecedent The noun or idea a pronoun **stands for**, usually just before it. Test: replace the pronoun with it.	**“where”** A **place** mentioned just before it: “outside the bedroom, **where** it cannot call…” → outside the bedroom.
Five context clues Definition · synonym · antonym/contrast · example · general sense.	**Fill-in method** 1. **Grammar**: noun, verb or adjective? 2. **Meaning**: test it in the sentence. 3. **Spelling**: must be exact.

Session 2: Practice

Exercises 1 and 2 use the reading text printed in Practice 1.

Exercise 1: Section B, false statements

2 marks, 10 min

The following statements are false because they misinterpret the meaning stated or conveyed in the selection. Rewrite them correctly.

1. Most young adults in the survey check where a story comes from before sharing it. (0.5)

2. Calm facts hold our attention longer than anger and fear. (0.5)

3. Rana says that a headline now sells a story instead of summarising it. (0.5)

4. Rana ran a fact-checking page before she shared the false photo. (0.5)

Exercise 2: Sections E and F

2 marks, 10 min

E. Based on contextual clues, choose the right word from the box for each blank. *Box: circulate (P2), sensational (P4), credibility (P5), verify (P7)*

1. The bank called me to _____ my identity before the transfer. (0.25)
2. Fans helped the clip _____ across the country in a single night. (0.25)
3. A scientist who hides her data damages her _____. (0.25)
4. “Shocking secret revealed!” is a typical _____ headline. (0.25)

F. What does each of the pronouns, bold-typed in the selection, refer to?

1. **she** (paragraph 1) (0.25)
2. **which** (paragraph 3) (0.25)
3. **where** (paragraph 8) (0.25)
4. **it** (paragraph 9) (0.25)

Exercise 3: Timed mini-paper

7.5 marks, 30 min

In the following selection, the writer describes a small library in a Lebanese village that lends seeds instead of books. Read it carefully, and then answer the questions that follow.

The Seed Library

Original practice text written for this platform. The village and people are invented.

1 Every Saturday morning, a line forms outside the old school in the mountain village of Kfar Zeit. The people waiting are not there for books. They are there for seeds.

2 The idea began with Hiba Sleiman, a retired biology teacher **who** noticed that the farmers around her were buying expensive imported seeds every season. “Our grandparents never bought seeds,” she remembers. “They kept the best ones from each harvest and shared them with the neighbours.” She decided to bring that habit back.

3 The library works like any other. Members borrow a packet of seeds in spring, and after the harvest they return twice as many seeds as they took. Each packet carries a small card that describes the plant, its season and the family who grew it. Today, the shelves hold more than 140 local varieties, from mountain thyme to a small, sweet tomato that had almost disappeared.

4 Local seeds matter because they have adapted to the region over hundreds of years. They need less water and fewer chemicals than many imported types, a real advantage as summers grow hotter and drier. Moreover, when farmers save their own seeds, they no longer depend on prices set far away.

5 The library has also brought people together. Older farmers teach teenagers how to dry and store seeds, while students design the cards and run the library's online page. "I used to think farming was for my grandfather's generation," says Jad, sixteen. "Now I see it is about our future."

6 Hiba hopes that other villages will follow. "A seed is a small thing," she says, "but **it** holds a whole history inside. When we share it, we share that history too."

A. Answer each question in 1–4 complete sentences using your own words.

1. Based on paragraph 2, identify two reasons that led Hiba to start the seed library. (01)

2. Scan paragraph 3 for two rules that members of the library follow. (01)

3. Based on paragraph 4, explain two advantages of local seeds. (01)

4. Based on paragraph 5, infer how Jad's view of farming has changed. (01)

B. The following statements are false. Rewrite them correctly.

1. Hiba's grandparents bought new seeds every season. (0.5)

2. Local seeds need more water than many imported types. (0.5)

E. Fill in the blanks with words from the box. *Box: imported (P2), varieties (P3), adapted (P4), depend (P4)*

1. Camels have _____ to life in the desert. (0.25)

2. The market sells ten _____ of olives. (0.25)

3. Small shops _____ on loyal customers. (0.25)

4. Most of the country's fuel is _____ by ship. (0.25)

F. What does each bold-typed word refer to?

1. **who** (paragraph 2) (0.25)

2. **it** (paragraph 6) (0.25)

Answer key

Session 1: Lesson (self-checks)

Task 1. b) Yes. The skeleton shows a problem (false news spreads through social media), its causes, its costs and a solution.

Task 2. 1–C, 2–D, 3–B, 4–A

Task 3. 1. Identify; 2. Infer; 3. Explain / clarify; 4. List / locate; 5. Evaluate; 6. Identify; 7. Infer; 8. Explain / clarify

Task 4. 1. Literal; 2. Inferential; 3. Critical; 4. Literal; 5. Inferential; 6. Critical

Task 5. c) Right. Clue: she “shared it at once”. Knowledge: acting at once means acting without checking.

Task 6. a) Yes. A student who now checks posts for others has clearly changed how she treats news online.

Session 1: Practice, Exercise 1: Section A, exam style

1. First, Rana shared the photo immediately, while she was still shocked. Second, she did not check where or when the photo had been taken, so she spread a false story. *0.5 for each mistake.*

2. First, algorithms push alarming posts to the top because anger and fear keep users scrolling longer. Second, websites earn money from every click, so they use exaggerated headlines to attract readers. *0.5 for each reason.*

3. When false reports spread, people stop trusting all news, so even honest journalists lose credibility. Moreover, since each person mostly sees opinions like his or her own, society divides into groups that no longer listen to each other. *0.5 for each harm.*

4. Before sharing a post, an individual could check who published it, when, and whether trusted sources confirm it. A university could support student fact-checking groups or offer courses that train students to judge the media critically. *0.5 for each measure.*

Session 1: Practice, Exercise 2: Decode before you answer

1. (a) Identify. (b) Literal: the findings are stated. (c) Two ideas, 0.5 each.

2. (a) Infer. (b) Inferential: the attitude is suggested. (c) The attitude plus a justification from the text (0.5 + 0.5).

3. (a) Evaluate (judge). (b) Critical: beyond the lines, you need your own view. (c) A clear position plus one reason with an example.

4. (a) Explain. (b) Inferential: you show how the anecdote links to the main idea. (c) What the story shows, and how it leads to the thesis.

Session 1: Practice, Exercise 3: Own words

1. Many young people make the same error that Rana made.

2. Financial interest is another cause of the problem.

3. Instead of avoiding the news, people should learn to judge it carefully.

Session 2: Lesson (self-checks)

Task 1. 1. General/specific: Three out of four young adults in the survey get their news mainly from social media. 2. Cause/effect: False news, shown to like-minded users, divides communities. 3. Wrong person: Ziad Khoury says that attention has become the product. 4. Antonym: Algorithms push the most alarming posts to the top of the feed. 5. Wrong order: Rana shared the photo at once and only later learned it was old.

Task 2. b) Exactly. The trap was “all”; only some families use the basket. Everything else stays.

Task 3. c) Yes: “but” sets up a contrast with “calm”, so the word means the opposite: alarmed, nervous.

Task 4. a) Right: the phrase after the comma explains the word directly.

Task 5. 1. circulate; 2. credibility; 3. verify; 4. sensational

Session 2: Practice, Exercise 1: Section B, false statements

1. Fewer than one in five young adults in the survey check where a story comes from before sharing it. *Trap: general/specific.*

2. Anger and fear hold our attention longer than calm facts. *Trap: the comparison is reversed.*

3. Ziad Khoury, a journalism lecturer, says that a headline now often sells a story instead of summarising it. *Trap: wrong person.*

4. Rana **started** a fact-checking page **after** she shared the false photo. *Trap: wrong order.*

Session 2: Practice, Exercise 2: Sections E and F

1. verify

2. circulate

3. credibility

4. sensational

1. Rana

2. the content

3. their campus

4. the media

Session 2: Practice, Exercise 3: Timed mini-paper

1. First, she saw that local farmers were paying a lot for foreign seeds every season. Second, she wanted to revive the old custom of keeping the best seeds and sharing them with neighbours. *0.5 for each.*

2. Members borrow seeds in spring, and after the harvest they must give back double the amount they borrowed. *0.5 for each rule. Accept: each packet comes with a card describing the plant.*

3. Since local seeds have adjusted to the region for centuries, they use less water and fewer chemicals, which matters as summers become hotter. Also, farmers who keep their own seeds are no longer controlled by foreign prices. *0.5 for each advantage.*

4. Jad used to see farming as an old-fashioned activity for older people. Through the library, he now sees it as important for his own generation’s future. *0.5 for the old view, 0.5 for the new one.*

1. Hiba’s grandparents **never bought seeds**; they kept the best ones from each harvest.

2. Local seeds need **less** water than many imported types.

1. adapted
2. varieties
3. depend
4. imported

1. Hiba Sleiman
2. a seed